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Flock Safety officials, police to talk license plate readers at Fort Wayne City Council

Devan Filchak | The Journal Gazette

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An automatic license plate reader by Flock Safety is shown.

Courtesy Flock Safety

More information about automatic license plate readers that have drawn concern from some Fort Wayne City Council members and residents is expected be shared on Tuesday.

Flock Safety provides cameras at dozens of intersections in Fort Wayne, and the Fort Wayne Police Department recently launched a pilot program in which technology detects noises, such as gunshots and other signs of distress, and immediately alerts police.

Police officials nearly three weeks ago asked council members to approve a renewal of the police department's contract with Flock Safety for the 36 license plate readers.

This was the first time council members saw a contract with the company, and they expressed surprise and concern. A few members referenced dozens of concerned citizens they heard from.

Concerns have focused on the level of surveillance, how the data will be used, a lack of public visibility to audit how the program is used and what agencies can access the information.

The city started using Flock cameras in 2024. Last month was the first time a contract required council's approval because of the cost.

The renewal contract is for \$120,250. Departments typically don't have to get council's approval on contracts below \$100,000.

The first contract was for eight cameras for about \$25,000. The next contract was about \$93,000 for 28 more cameras, and it was paid for with a justice assistance grant, Detective John Greenlee said in May.

Chief P.J. Smith knew that council members would want to know about the technology, so he informed them earlier this year after he was appointed to the department's top position.

Council members make initial decisions at committee sessions and then take final votes during regular meetings. The May 26 meeting when Flock was discussed included both sessions.

During the initial vote, the contract renewal failed with a vote of 4-5. The opposition was from Councilwoman Rohli Booker, D-6th, and Councilmen Paul Ensley, R-1st; Nathan Hartman, R-3rd; Russ Jehl, R-2nd; and Scott Myers, R-4th.

Before the final vote, Jehl asked to hold the legislation until July 14 to allow officials to address some of the civil liberties questions that have raised concerns. Hartman then recommended extending the date until July 28, a move that was unanimously approved.

Flock Safety representatives and police officials are scheduled to address council this week. The agenda released Friday does not offer further details, and the contract is not scheduled for discussion or action. Greenlee shared some information in May that he hoped would quell

concerns.

The cameras do not use facial recognition, and the information is not tied to individuals, according to Flock's website. They capture only vehicles, including license plates. That information has been used to find suspects and solve crimes, including homicide cases, Greenlee said.

Officers have to be trained before using the system, and they must use a case number to access the data.

Council members' questions uncovered more concerns. Officers can use a fake case number to access data, Greenlee said after a query from Councilwoman Rohli Booker, D-6th.

Smith said the system can be audited, but it hasn't been in its first two years.

People have also questioned what agencies can access the data. Greenlee said to share data, the department has to agree with the specific department, and more than 2,000 agencies have been approved. More than 5,000 law enforcement agencies use Flock, according to its website.

The Flock Safety presentation is scheduled for the beginning Tuesday's 5:30 p.m. meeting. It will end with public comment.

City Council meets in Room 035 at Citizens Square, 200 E. Berry St.

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MORE INFORMATION



Fort Wayne City Council unsure about continuing Flock license plate readers

Fort Wayne Police Department to test system that detects sound of gunshots, distress

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